A Story of War and Valiant Hearts

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Educators are always in the lookout of new and innovative ways to teach their classes, and video games may be one of the most immersive - and also unexplored - options to achieve this purpose. Valiant Hearts is a video game released in 2014 by the company Ubisoft and shows one of the most interesting approaches to highlight the events of World War I. Standing out from the usual shooter video games without glorifying violence as part of the gameplay, by showing the terrible consequences of war. The story of the game begins in the year 1914, after the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand. France deports German citizens in anticipation to the war. Karl, one of the deported Germans, is separated from his wife Marie and son Victor to fight in the German army. Likewise, Karl's father-in-law, Emile, is drafted into the French army. Before going into battle, Emile stops soldiers from harassing Freddie, an American who joined the French army after his wife was killed in a German bombing commanded by Baron Von Dorf. Emile is sent to the Battle of the Frontiers where he is wounded and captured by Von Dorf. Forced to cook, he encounters Karl as a soldier of the Baron's platoon. After the German retreat due to an attack on the camp, Emile manages to escape from the rubble thanks to the help of Walt, a German war dog. Later, he reunites with Freddie, who rescues him and Walt from death. After being assigned to another battle, the trio escape the chlorine gas attacks, and are saved by Anna, a Belgian veterinary student working as a battlefield nurse and tracking her father, captured by Von Dorf. The group decides to take revenge on Von Dorf who has affected their lives and at the same time, rescue Anna's father and help Karl return to his family. The video game takes players through the historical journey in emblematic events and battles of the Great War. A game of puzzles and adventure divided in four chapters - composed of several sections ranging from stealth to rhythmic segments - which tell the story of the characters mentioned above, passing through significative areas, and providing information through short prologues of the historical moment in which the characters were involved. Additionally little-known historical details can be obtained through collectibles in the form of real objects of the war - items from the different armies and civilians - hidden throughout each level. Developed with the intention of reminding players of WWI on its centenary, the game ensured historical accuracy by listening to relevant wartime sources, reconstructing the experiences recounted in letters written by soldiers on both sides and visiting the remains of French trenches. With these things in consideration, video games such as Valiant Hearts, could be a more interactive and fun approach to accompany learning. Through challenges, music, and endearing stories without losing sight of the rigor and accuracy required in teaching.